

A systematic review of social media impact on psychological well-being among children, adolescents, and young adults in arab countries

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ARTICLE INFO

Keywords:

Adolescents
Arab countries
Mental health
Social media use
Systematic review

ABSTRACT

Background: Social media is a major part of daily life for youth worldwide, including in Arab countries. Although it offers avenues for connection and information, growing concerns exist around its psychological impacts. This review aims to synthesize existing evidence on the association between social media use and mental health outcomes among children, adolescents, and young adults in Arab countries.

Methods: We systematically searched PubMed, Scopus, EMBASE, and Web of Science for peer-reviewed studies published until October 2025. Inclusion criteria targeted observational studies involving participants aged ≤ 25 years from Arab League countries, focusing on the relationship between social media use and mental health indicators. Data were extracted and quality assessed using the Newcastle-Ottawa Scale adaptation for cross-sectional designs.

Results: Twenty-one cross-sectional studies, encompassing over 15,000 participants with a mean age ranging from 13 to 25 years and representing multiple Arab countries, met the inclusion criteria. Findings revealed consistent associations between high or problematic social media use and adverse mental health outcomes, including anxiety, depression, sleep disturbances, and academic decline. Several studies highlighted emotional investment and nighttime use as key mediators. Sleep disruption and academic interference were common outcomes across settings.

Conclusion: High levels of emotionally charged social media use among Arab children, adolescents, and young adults are associated with significant psychological and functional challenges, emphasizing the need for culturally tailored digital literacy and early screening. However, the predominance of cross-sectional designs across the included studies limits causal inference and underscores the necessity for future longitudinal and experimental research.

1. Introduction

Over the past two decades, social media has transformed the way individuals communicate, connect, and consume information (Gazi et al., 2024). With platforms like Instagram, Snapchat, TikTok, Facebook, and X (formerly Twitter) becoming integral to daily life, the extent of social media use has rapidly expanded—particularly among young people (Sabar et al., 2024). In the Arab world, this trend is even more

pronounced due to increased internet accessibility, widespread smartphone ownership, and a youthful demographic (Radcliffe et al., 2023). For many Arab youth, social media platforms serve as spaces for self-expression, entertainment, education, and social interaction (Aissani et al., 2024, Abu Backer and Awad, 2025). However, growing evidence shows that intensive or problematic use of social media may have negative effects on mental health (Khalaf et al., 2023, Karim et al., 2020).

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<https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ajp.2025.104793>

Received 30 August 2025; Received in revised form 29 November 2025; Accepted 6 December 2025

Available online 8 December 2025

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Research from Western contexts has linked such use to increased risks of anxiety, depression, sleep disturbances, body dissatisfaction, and poor academic performance (Yu et al., 2024, Zubair et al., 2023). These associations appear to be more pronounced among adolescents and young adults, an age group undergoing critical emotional and cognitive development (Agyapong-Opoku et al., 2025). The mechanisms proposed include upward social comparisons, cyberbullying, fear of missing out (FoMO), disrupted sleep patterns, and reduced real-life social interaction (Sulaiman et al., 2024).

In the Arab region, the intersection between social media and mental health is shaped by unique cultural, social, and religious dynamics. Mental health stigma remains prevalent in many Arab societies, often discouraging open discussion or help-seeking behavior (Krstanoska-Blazeska et al., 2021, Elshamy et al., 2023). In this context, social media could play a dual role: on one hand, offering opportunities for mental health awareness and peer support, and on the other, exacerbating psychological distress through exposure to unrealistic standards, online harassment, or emotional over-investment (Sala et al., 2024). Additionally, parental expectations, gender norms, and socio-political pressures may influence both how Arab youth engage with social media and how it affects their mental health (Ali, 2018).

Despite the global rise in research on digital health and social media, a significant gap remains in region-specific evidence from the Arab world. Most existing studies are limited in scope, focus on single countries, or examine specific outcomes in isolation, making it difficult to draw broader conclusions. Moreover, few studies have synthesized the available data to provide a comprehensive understanding of the prevalence, patterns, and psychological effects of social media use among youth in Arab countries (Abdulsalim et al., 2025, Khalil et al., 2020, Malak et al., 2021).

Given these gaps, this systematic review aims to evaluate the association between social media use and mental health outcomes among young people in Arab countries. We examined patterns of usage, assessed the association with mental health, and evaluated the strength and quality of the current evidence base. By explicitly addressing the lack of synthesis in this area, this review contributes to a clearer understanding of how digital life intersects with psychological well-being in the Arab world.

2. Methods

This systematic review was conducted with the Preferred Reporting Items for Systematic Reviews and Meta-Analyses (PRISMA) guidelines (Page et al., 2021) and the Cochrane handbook for systematic reviews (Cumpston et al., 2022). The protocol was registered on PROSPERO (CRD420251113064).

2.1. Information sources and search strategy

A systematic literature search was conducted across four electronic databases: PubMed, Scopus, EMBASE, and Web of Science. The search included studies published in English from inception until October 2025. Keywords and Boolean operators were used to combine terms related to social media use, mental health, and Arab countries. Reference lists of included articles were also screened to identify additional eligible studies. The detailed search strategy is shown in Table S1.

2.2. Inclusion and exclusion criteria

Studies were included if they involved participants from Arab League countries and examined social media use in relation to mental health outcomes. Eligible studies included children, adolescents, or young adults with a mean participant age of ≤ 25 years, allowing inclusion of studies where a small proportion of participants were older, provided the sample's mean age was ≤ 25 years and primarily represented the target age group. In addition, included studies were required to be

observational in design (cross-sectional or longitudinal), include at least 20 participants, to ensure adequate methodological rigor, and be published in peer-reviewed journals. Studies were excluded if they examined only general internet or smartphone use, included clinical or non-Arab populations, did not report on both social media use and mental health outcomes, were published in languages other than English, or were opinion or editorial articles.

2.3. Study selection

After removing duplicates, titles and abstracts were independently screened by two reviewers. Full texts were retrieved for potentially eligible studies, and inclusion was determined based on predefined criteria. Disagreements were resolved by a third reviewer.

2.4. Data extraction

Data were extracted independently by two reviewers using a standardized form, which was piloted prior to use; disagreements were resolved through discussion or consultation with a third reviewer. Extracted information included study setting, population, sample size, age, sex distribution, and main findings.

2.5. Quality assessment

The quality of the included cross-sectional studies was assessed using the Newcastle-Ottawa Scale adaptation for cross-sectional designs (NOS-cs), which evaluates three key domains: selection of study participants, assessment of exposure(s) and outcome(s), and control for confounding variables (Carra et al., 2025). Each included study was rated on a nine-star scale with a maximum of 2 stars for selection, 4 stars for exposure/outcome, and 3 stars for confounding, reflecting methodological rigor. Studies were categorized as low risk of bias (7–9 stars), moderate risk (4–6 stars), or high risk (0–3 stars). Two independent reviewers conducted the assessment, resolving discrepancies through consensus or third-party adjudication.

2.6. Data synthesis

A narrative synthesis was conducted to summarize findings. This involved organizing results thematically (e.g., anxiety, depression, academic performance, sleep quality), exploring patterns, and identifying moderators such as gender and age. A meta-analysis was considered but not conducted due to heterogeneity in outcome measures and study designs. If future studies yield more homogeneous data, quantitative methods such as subgroup analysis or meta-analysis could be undertaken to better address heterogeneity.

3. Results

Out of 1220 records identified from four databases, 495 duplicates were removed, leaving 725 for screening. After excluding 687 records during title and abstract screening, 38 full-text reports were assessed for eligibility. Seventeen studies were excluded for reasons such as irrelevant outcomes, age criteria, conference publication, or not focusing on social media. Ultimately, 21 studies met the inclusion criteria and were incorporated into the systematic review (Abdulsalim et al., 2025, Al-Garni et al., 2024, Almansoor, 2023, Alsunni and Latif, 2021, Archou et al., 2025, Atwan et al., 2024, Faqihi et al., 2024, Fekih-Romdhane et al., 2024, Khalil et al., 2020, Kolhar et al., 2021, Louragli et al., 2019, Malak et al., 2021, Mohamed et al., 2025, Sfeir et al., 2023, Shanshal et al., 2024, Vally et al., 2023, Zeeni et al., 2018, El Hayek et al., 2025, Elrewany et al., 2025, Jameel et al., 2025, Muyidi, 2025). The study selection process is illustrated in Fig. 1 (PRISMA flow diagram).

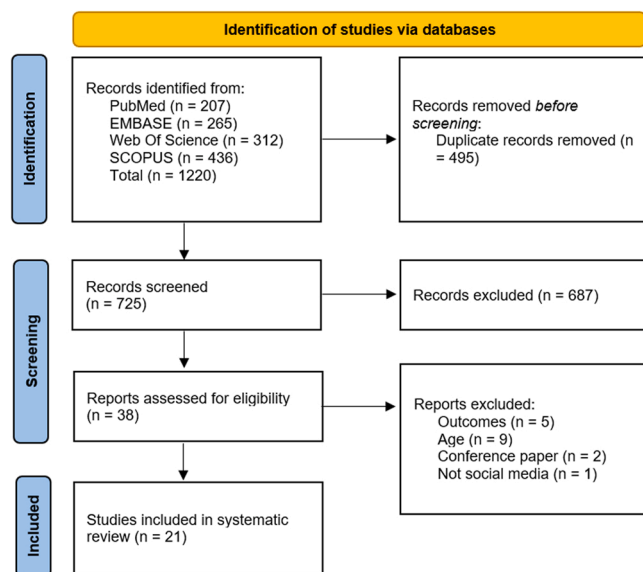


Fig. 1. The PRISMA flow diagram of the study selection process.

3.1. Baseline and summary of the included studies

Twenty-one cross-sectional studies conducted between 2018 and 2025 across Arab countries investigated the impact of social media use, encompassing a combined sample of over 15,000 participants, with individual study sizes ranging from 154 to 2856. These studies were carried out in Saudi Arabia (8 studies), Egypt (2), Lebanon (4), Iraq (1), Jordan (1), Morocco (2), Palestine (1), and multi-nations (2). Populations studied included university, high school, and middle school students, with mean ages spanning 10–24 years and male representation ranging from 23 % to 57 %. Key negative outcomes included increased levels of depression, anxiety, stress, sleep disruption, and reduced academic performance. Most studies relied on self-report measures and were based in educational settings. Further details are shown in Table 1. Details on the measurement instruments and cut-off values used for key outcomes are provided in Tables S2 and S3. Variations between studies prevented the conduction of a meta-analysis.

3.2. Quality assessment

Among the included studies, eight were classified as "Low Risk of Bias," reflecting strong methodology, especially in sample selection, validated measurement tools, and confounder adjustment (Abdulsalim et al., 2025, Malak et al., 2021, Mohamed et al., 2025, Vally et al., 2023, Atwan et al., 2024, Fekih-Romdhane et al., 2024, Elrewany et al., 2025, Jameel et al., 2025). The other 13 studies were rated as "Moderate Risk of Bias," primarily due to limitations such as non-random or less representative sampling, reliance on non-validated measurement instruments, or limited adjustment for confounders. No studies reached a high risk-of-bias rating, indicating that the body of evidence included in this review overall has moderate to high internal validity according to the NOS-cs. Table S4

3.3. Qualitative synthesis

3.3.1. Prevalence of mental health conditions and social media addiction

Studies reveal widespread problematic social media use and addiction among Arab youth, accompanied by notable mental health symptoms. High prevalence of social media use (SMU) among Arab youth is often accompanied by social media addiction, defined as excessive, compulsive use that disrupts daily life, relationships, and mental well-being. Among high school students, (Khalil et al., 2020) identified

internet addiction in 65.6 % of participants, accompanied by high rates of psychological symptoms. Studies focusing on university students also revealed widespread problematic use: (Abdulsalim et al., 2025) reported that over half felt addicted to social media, while (Archou et al., 2025) found 72 % acknowledged addiction, with WhatsApp, Instagram, and Facebook being the most used platforms. Similarly, (Almansoor, 2023) noted that 70.1 % of their sample displayed moderate mental health symptoms associated with frequent SMU.

Within medical student populations, (Mohamed et al., 2025) reported particularly high engagement, with 82.8 % admitting excessive internet use. Research among youth more broadly showed comparable findings: (Atwan et al., 2024) observed addiction in nearly half their sample, with Facebook remaining the most common platform (92 %).

(Elrewany et al., 2025) found a 43.3 % prevalence of Internet addiction among youth aged 15–24 in five Eastern Mediterranean countries, with social anxiety strongly mediating addiction, while (Jameel et al., 2025) reported high social media addiction among Saudi university students.

3.3.2. Variables linked to mental health disorders

Multiple behavioral, psychological, and physiological factors contribute to mental health challenges linked to social media use.

3.3.2.1. Behavioral predictors. Time spent on social media consistently emerged as a strong risk factor. (Archou et al., 2025) reported that daily hours online predicted perceived addiction, while (Shanshal et al., 2024) demonstrated that frequent and prolonged use were significant predictors of both addiction and depression. Similarly, (Al-Garni et al., 2024) found that extended engagement with social media strongly predicted poor sleep quality.

3.3.2.2. Psychological predictors. Depression repeatedly surfaced as a central factor. (Alsunni and Latif, 2021) observed strong associations between depression, anxiety, and emotional investment in social media among undergraduates. (Vally et al., 2023) highlighted that depression predicted addictive use through reduced personal control. (Shanshal et al., 2024) further noted that depressive symptoms amplified the effects of frequent social media use, while (Fekih-Romdhane et al., 2024) showed that problematic use was linked to higher anxiety, although mindfulness reduced this impact. (Elrewany et al., 2025) identified social anxiety as a key mediator increasing youth vulnerability to Internet addiction, while (Jameel et al., 2025) found that insomnia mediates the link between social media addiction and depression.

3.3.2.3. Physiological predictors. Poor sleep quality was closely linked to problematic social media use. (Archou et al., 2025) associated sleep disturbance with perceived addiction, while (Shanshal et al., 2024) found that low sleep quality intensified the relationship between social media use and depression. (Al-Garni et al., 2024) emphasized that prolonged engagement and depressive symptoms jointly predicted poor sleep, illustrating the interplay between emotional, behavioral, and physiological dimensions.

3.3.3. Body image concerns and disordered eating

Dissatisfaction with body image and related eating disorders are increasingly recognized as consequences of social media use among young Arabs. (Sfeir et al., 2023) found that problematic social media use was directly and indirectly associated with bulimia nervosa symptoms. This relationship was mediated by elevated levels of anxiety and depression, highlighting the psychological pathways through which social media may influence disordered eating patterns. Similarly, (Zeeni et al., 2018) reported that frequent use of platforms like Facebook and Instagram was correlated with body image dissatisfaction and increased risk for eating disorders, particularly among young adults in Lebanon.

(El Hayek et al., 2025) found that depression partially mediates the

Table 1

Baseline characteristics and summary of the included studies.

ID	Country	Sample (University)	Study duration	Study Design	Sample Number	Mean Age, years	Sex (% male)	Findings
Abdulsalim et al. (2025)	Saudi Arabia	Qassim University (Medical & Non-Medical)	2022–2023	Cross-sectional	269	22.28	57.00 %	More than 30 % used SM 4–6 hrs/day. Significant association between SM use, anxiety, and academic performance.
Archou et al. (2025)	Morocco	Nursing Students, Meknes	2023	Cross-sectional	300	20.28	27.70 %	72 % perceived addiction. 70 % reported psychological issues (88 % loneliness, 37.8 % anxiety, 15.6 % depression).
El Hayek et al. (2025)	Lebanon	Lebanese high schools (general population sample)	Dec 2023–Jan 2024	Cross-sectional	336	15.7	36.60 %	41.7 % problematic social media use. Depression partially mediates association between social media addiction and body dysmorphic concerns.
Elrewany et al. (2025)	Egypt, Saudi Arabia, Libya, Jordan, Syria	Multiple universities	August to October 2024	Cross-sectional	2095	20.8	46.80 %	43.3 % prevalence of internet addiction. Internet addiction strongly associated with social anxiety; being younger, female, rural, or in mid-adolescence elevated risk.
Jameel et al. (2025)	Saudi Arabia	3 major universities, Riyadh, Jeddah, Dhahran	October to November 2024	Cross-sectional	727	Majority between 18 and 22 years	66.86 %	Social media addiction positively associated with insomnia and depressive symptoms. Insomnia mediates the link between SM addiction and mental health issues.
Mohamed et al. (2025)	Egypt	Zagazig University (Faculty of Medicine)	Not specified	Cross-sectional	627	21.06	48.80 %	16.6 % showed Facebook addiction, associated with lower academic performance and higher anxiety, depression, and stress.
Muyidi et al. 2025	Saudi Arabia	Multi-university undergraduates (>40 institutions)	November 2022	Cross-sectional	715	NR	29.90 %	Greater use of self-presentation strategies (exemplification, ingratiation, self-promotion) linked to more SM time, more followers, anonymity, and lower psychological well-being.
Shanshal et al. 2025	Iraq	University of Mosul (Pharmacy students)	November to December 2021	Cross-sectional	603	NR	32.20 %	Strong correlation between SM addiction and depression.
Al-Garni et al. (2024)	Saudi Arabia	Secondary School Students (Aseer Region)	March 12 to March 17, 2023	Cross-sectional	961	16.7	40.70 %	TikTok use, high SM time, and depressive symptoms predicted poor sleep quality.
Atwan et al. (2024)	Palestine	Al-Quds University, An-Najah National University	Not specified	Cross-sectional	722	16–20 years	30.10 %	45.8 % exhibited SNA. Negative correlation with well-being. Quality of life mediated impact.
Faqihi et al. (2024)	Saudi Arabia	Nationwide adolescents (not university-based)	August and November 2023	Cross-sectional	2856	10–24 years	23.00 %	Low overall mental health impact; sleep disturbance and older age associated with higher risk.
Fekih-Romdhane et al. (2024)	Lebanon	Multiple Lebanese universities	July and September 2021	Cross-sectional	363	22.65	38.30 %	Problematic SM use linked to anxiety; trait mindfulness moderates effect.
Al Mansoor et al. 2023	Saudi Arabia	Adolescents, not university-based	April and June 2023	Cross-sectional	154	15.6	33.80 %	Problematic social media use negatively associated with mental health and sleep.
Sfeir et al. (2023)	Lebanon	Multiple Lebanese universities	July and September 2021	Cross-sectional	363	22.65	38.30 %	Problematic social media use was directly and indirectly (via anxiety and depression) associated with bulimia nervosa.
Vally et al. (2023)	Egypt & UAE	Two universities (Egypt, UAE)	February to May 2021	Cross-sectional	1322	19.5	24.60 %	Sense of control mediated the relationship between depression and addictive SM use.
Alsunni et al. 2021	Saudi Arabia	Imam Abdulrahman Bin Faisal University	2019–2020	Cross-sectional	893	23.91	48.90 %	Higher emotional investment in SM significantly related to anxiety and depression.
Kolhar et al. (2021)	Egypt	High school students	Not specified	Cross-sectional	584	16.1	41.40 %	92.8 % showed Facebook use, and associated with depression, dysthymia, social anxiety, suicide.
Malak et al. (2021)	Jordan	University students from two institutions	September 2018 to December 2018	Cross-sectional	510	21.38	31.40 %	Social media addiction indirectly affected academic performance via stress, anxiety, and depression.
Khalil et al. (2020)	Saudi Arabia	University students	September to December 2019	Cross-sectional survey	300	Majority among 19–25 years	0.00 %	Prolonged nonacademic use of social networking sites can impair academic performance, disrupt sleep and social interactions, and increase risk for

(continued on next page)

Table 1 (continued)

ID	Country	Sample (University)	Study duration	Study Design	Sample Number	Mean Age, years	Sex (% male)	Findings
Louragli et al. (2019)	Morocco	Middle and high school students	April 2017	Cross-sectional	541	15.24	44.90 %	physical inactivity and mental health issues. Facebook addiction negatively correlated with academic performance and positively associated with anxiety and nomophobia.
Zeeni et al. (2018)	Lebanon	Lebanese university students	Not specified	Cross-sectional	244	Between 18 and 23	26.10 %	Social media use linked to body image dissatisfaction, ED risk, depression, and anxiety.

SM: Social Media, SNA: Social Network Addiction, NR: Not Reported, ED: Eating Disorder, UAE: United Arab Emirates. Main cut off values: PHQ-9 $\geq$ 10 (depression); GAD-7 $\geq$ 10 (anxiety); DASS-21 $\geq$ 14 (depression), $\geq$ 10 (anxiety); CES-D $\geq$ 16 (depression); HADS $\geq$ 8 (anxiety); PSQI $>$ 5 (poor sleep); ISI $\geq$ 15 (insomnia); Bergen SMA Scale/CIUS/SMAQ $>$ 19–24 (addiction, varied). Full details in Tables S2–S3.

link between problematic social media use and body dysmorphic concerns among Lebanese adolescents, highlighting depression as a key factor connecting social media addiction to body image disturbances.

3.3.4. Sleep disturbance and insomnia associated with social media interaction

Evidence shows that engagement with social media often disrupts sleep patterns and heightens insomnia symptoms in youth. (Al-Garni et al., 2024) found that students who spent more time on TikTok and other platforms, such as Snapchat, Instagram, and YouTube, exhibited significantly poorer sleep quality. They revealed that depressive symptoms and prolonged social media use predicted disrupted sleep patterns, with (Faqihi et al., 2024) similarly reporting that sleep disturbances were a common adverse effect, particularly among older adolescents aged 16–24 years. These disturbances were closely linked to night-time use and emotional dependency on social media.

(Elrewany et al., 2025) reported that online learning increases Internet addiction risk through social anxiety, both highlighting interconnected behavioral and physiological pathways affecting mental health among Arab youth.

Furthermore, (Alsunni and Latif, 2021) emphasized that the emotional investment in social media, rather than just screen time, contributed significantly to sleep issues.

3.3.5. Gender and age as moderators of mental health risks

Age and gender significantly shape the risk and manifestation of social media addiction and related mental health outcomes. (Khalil et al., 2020) reported higher rates of Facebook and internet gaming addiction among males, with psychiatric comorbidities—including depression, panic disorders, and social anxiety—considered as influencing variables. (Atwan et al., 2024) found that addiction rates increased progressively from adolescence to early adulthood, highlighting critical developmental stages of vulnerability. (Al-Garni et al., 2024) similarly observed greater prevalence of low sleep quality and depressive symptoms among adolescents with high social media use. (Atwan et al., 2024) also noted that females were more likely to exhibit social media addiction, reflecting differences in online engagement and emotional investment. (Elrewany et al., 2025) found that younger age and female gender increase vulnerability to Internet addiction, partially mediated by social anxiety, while males and urban residents showed lower risk.

3.3.6. Physical and psychological health effects of social media usage

Social media use has been consistently linked to both physical and psychological health consequences. (Archou et al., 2025) reported high rates of physical problems—such as eye strain, neck pain, headaches, and fatigue—alongside psychological effects including loneliness, anxiety, depression, and eating disorders. (Al-Garni et al., 2024) emphasized disrupted sleep, poor sleep quality, and high daytime dysfunction with prolonged daily use. Similar findings were echoed by (Kolhar et al.,

2021, Sfeir et al., 2023), who documented depression, anxiety, loneliness, and disordered eating associated with excessive use. (Zeeni et al., 2018) further noted that stress, anxiety, and depression were positively correlated with negative attitudes towards technology. (Malak et al., 2021) reinforced this, showing that addiction to social media was strongly linked to increased stress, anxiety, and depression. (Jameel et al., 2025) found that insomnia mediates the link between social media addiction and depression among Saudi university students, underscoring its mental and physical toll. Similarly, (El Hayek et al., 2025) reported that problematic social media use among Lebanese adolescents is associated with body dysmorphic concerns, partially mediated by depression. (Muyidi, 2025) observed that increased social media use among Saudi young adults promotes impression management behaviors linked to anxiety and low self-esteem, reflecting culturally influenced psychological effects.

3.3.7. Correlations between academic performance and mental health

Social media use has been consistently linked to academic underperformance. (Abdulsalim et al., 2025) found that higher anxiety scores were associated with lower cumulative GPAs, while (Mohamed et al., 2025) reported reduced study hours, poor performance, and increased failure rates among students with Facebook addiction. (Kolhar et al., 2021) similarly observed that excessive social media use disrupted learning and knowledge acquisition. (Shanshal et al., 2024) highlighted that many students expected improved outcomes in the absence of social media distractions. (Louragli et al., 2019) further demonstrated that higher Facebook addiction scores predicted weaker first-semester performance and were also associated with anxiety and nomophobia, suggesting both direct and indirect academic impacts. (Muyidi, 2025) found that social media use and self-presentation behaviors affect self-esteem and anxiety, indirectly influencing academic performance. A summary of the qualitative synthesis is shown in Table 2.

4. Discussion

This systematic review synthesized data from 21 cross-sectional studies conducted between 2018 and 2025 across Arab countries, assessing the relationship between social media use and mental health outcomes among children, adolescents, and young adults. The cumulative sample exceeded 15,000 participants, mostly comprising school and university students aged between 10 and 24 years. Findings consistently showed that frequent or problematic use was linked to anxiety, depression, stress, sleep disturbances, and reduced academic performance.

Several patterns emerged from the analysis. First, high daily use was common, often exceeding four hours, driven by smartphone availability, digital connectivity, and limited alternatives for recreation and socialization (Abdul-Karim and Elareshi, 2016). Second, females were more likely than males to experience distress, possibly due to greater emotional investment in online interactions and heightened

Table 2
Summary of the qualitative synthesis.

Theme	Summary	Supporting Studies
Prevalence of Mental Health Conditions and Social Media Addiction	High prevalence of social media use and mental health symptoms across Arab states, with 65–83 % of samples showing moderate to severe addiction patterns. Facebook, WhatsApp, and Instagram are the most commonly used platforms.	Al Mansoor et al. (2023), Khalil et al. (2020), Mohamed et al. (2025), Atwan et al. (2024), Abdulsalim et al. (2025), Archou et al. (2025), Elrewany et al. (2025)
Risk Factors and Predictors of Mental Health Disorders	Key predictors include excessive internet/social media use, emotional investment in platforms, time spent online, psychological dependence, and reduced personal control. Depression both predicts and results from addictive social media use.	Alsunni et al. (2021), Archou et al. (2025), Vally et al. (2023), Shanshal et al. (2025), Al-Garni et al. (2024), Fekih-Romdhane et al. (2024), Elrewany et al. (2025)
Sleep Disturbance and Insomnia	Social media use significantly disrupts sleep patterns, with poor sleep quality linked to extended platform usage (especially TikTok, Snapchat, Instagram, YouTube). Night-time use and emotional dependency on social media are primary contributors to sleep issues.	Al-Garni et al. (2024), Faqihi et al. (2024), Alsunni et al. (2021)
Gender and Age as Risk Moderators	Females show higher rates of social media addiction, while males exhibit more gaming addiction and psychiatric comorbidities. Vulnerability increases linearly from adolescence to early adulthood, with young people being particularly at risk.	Al-Garni et al. (2024), Atwan et al. (2024), Khalil et al. (2020)
Academic Performance Impact	Strong negative correlation between social media addiction and academic achievement. Effects include decreased study hours, lower GPA, higher failure rates, and reduced learning efficiency. Students recognize academic improvement potential when free from social media distractions.	Abdulsalim et al. (2025), Mohamed et al. (2025), Kolhar et al. (2021), Shanshal et al. (2025), Louragli et al. (2019)
Physical and Psychological Health Effects	Extensive physical symptoms (72.3 % of users) including eye disorders, neck pain, headaches, and fatigue. Psychological impacts encompass loneliness, anxiety, depression, eating disorders, and increased stress levels with cascading mental health effects.	Archou et al. (2025), Al-Garni et al. (2024), Sfeir et al. (2023), Kolhar et al. (2021), Zeeni et al. (2018), Malak et al. (2021), Jameel et al. (2025), El-Hayek et al. (2025)
Body Image Concerns and Disordered Eating	Social media use directly and indirectly associated with body image dissatisfaction and eating	Sfeir et al. (2023), Zeeni et al. (2018), El Hayek et al. (2025)

Table 2 (continued)

Theme	Summary	Supporting Studies
	disorders, particularly bulimia nervosa. The relationship is mediated by elevated anxiety and depression, especially among young adults using visual platforms like Instagram and Facebook.	

vulnerability to body image concerns and peer comparisons (Twenge and Martin, 2020, Sagrera et al., 2022).

Third, disturbance was one of the most frequent reported consequences. Studies such as those by Al-Garni et al. (2024) and Faqihi et al. (2024) found that prolonged screen time and emotionally driven usage behaviors interfered with sleep quality, especially when usage occurred at night (Al-Garni et al., 2024, Faqihi et al., 2024). This relationship was amplified by the emotional content of interactions on social media, such as arguments, peer comparisons, or emotionally charged videos (Hyvärinen and Beck, 2018).

Fourth, academic performance was frequently negatively affected. Students who spent excessive time on social networking platforms often reported reduced concentration, procrastination, and disrupted study routines (Aljarrah et al., 2025). These behavioral patterns likely reflect displacement effects, where time spent on digital engagement replaces academic or restorative activities (Aljarrah et al., 2025).

Finally, while some studies acknowledged potential benefits such as social connection or mental health awareness, these were overshadowed by the psychological burdens of excessive and emotionally charged use, especially in the absence of digital literacy and self-regulation skills.

(Yu et al., 2024) conducted a scoping review of global studies and concluded that both cross-sectional and longitudinal research support an association between SMU and adverse outcomes, particularly poor sleep and mental health disturbances. They emphasized the developmental vulnerability of adolescents and the role of FOMO as a mediator of SMU and stress.

Similarly, (Mainoo et al., 2025) systematically reviewed 73 global studies and reported consistent positive associations between SMU and anxiety, depression, and sleep problems in both adolescents and adults. Notably, they identified nighttime use and emotional arousal as key risk factors.

In a complementary global review, (Ahmed et al., 2024) examined the relationship between social media use, mental health, and sleep across more than one million participants, including nearly 100,000 in meta-analyses. Their findings revealed small but significant links between both general and problematic social media use and higher levels of depression, anxiety, and sleep disturbances. They further highlighted algorithm-driven emotional arousal (e.g., infinite scrolling, push notifications) as a mechanism contributing to disrupted mood and sleep.

Similarly, a systematic review by (Khalaf et al., 2023), found consistent associations between social media use and adverse mental health outcomes—including depression, anxiety, and poor sleep—in adolescents and young adults globally.

When compared with our findings, the similarities are striking. Just as in global data, Arab youth show strong links between SMU and anxiety, depression, and sleep disruption. However, our review emphasizes additional region-specific moderators: cultural stigma surrounding mental health, restrictive gender norms, and strong family expectations. These factors may magnify the psychological burden of problematic SMU in Arab contexts, where adolescents often lack safe offline avenues for emotional expression.

The results suggest that problematic social media use among youth in Arab countries is common, multifactorial, and closely linked to mental health challenges. Importantly, Arab countries are not isolated from the global nature of this issue, which is increasingly recognized across

diverse contexts. Psychological theories such as the Cognitive-Behavioral Model of Internet Addiction and the Compensatory Internet Use Theory help explain this pattern (Davis, 2001). These models suggest that youth may use social media to regulate mood or escape stress, especially in contexts where mental health stigma limits emotional expression. Over time, this reliance can increase compulsive use patterns and reduce offline coping skills, contributing to psychological distress.

Social Comparison explains the high levels of anxiety and depression associated with social media (Garcia et al., 2013). Adolescents and young adults, already vulnerable to self-esteem fluctuations, may interpret idealized portrayals of peers as benchmarks for success, beauty, or happiness—triggering feelings of inadequacy, especially in collectivist cultures with strong social expectations (Merino et al., 2024). Linking theory to practice strengthens these implications. CBT-based strategies, such as cognitive restructuring and healthier coping skills, could be embedded in school counseling to limit compulsive social media use. Likewise, Social Comparison Theory can guide workshops that teach students to critically assess online portrayals of success and beauty, protecting self-esteem.

These insights have important implications for mental health promotion and digital literacy in Arab countries. School-based programs can incorporate education about healthy social media use, emotional regulation, and sleep hygiene (Lopes et al., 2021, Setia et al., 2024). Moreover, policymakers and tech platforms can consider culturally adapted interventions, such as in-app mental health resources in Arabic, time-limit nudges, or filtered content tailored to youth well-being (Naderbagi et al., 2024).

Clinicians, too, should recognize social media behavior as a potential indicator of psychological distress (Domoff et al., 2025). Simple screening questions about time spent online, emotional dependence on apps, or changes in sleep and academics could reveal early signs of emerging mental health issues. Equally important is the role of parents, who can model balanced technology use and maintain open communication with adolescents (Apdillah et al., 2022). Public health campaigns and community courses can raise awareness about social media's benefits and risks, reducing stigma and promoting healthier habits. Incorporating digital literacy and mental health education into school curricula would equip adolescents to critically assess online content and make informed choices (Alonzo and Popescu, 2021). These strategies emphasize that responsibility is shared among families, schools, healthcare providers, policymakers, and technology companies.

More broadly, the findings of this review align with wider concerns about youth mental health in the region and reinforce calls to strengthen culturally grounded psychiatric training and service capacity across Middle Eastern countries (Al-Huseini et al., 2025). In parallel, recent reflections on the Gaza conflict emphasize that psychiatrists and mental health systems must be prepared to respond proactively to conflict-related trauma and digital exposure to war, particularly among young people (Tandon et al., 2024).

4.1. Strengths and limitations

A key strength of this review lies in its focus on a demographically specific and culturally underrepresented population: youth in Arab countries. This regionally targeted synthesis fills an important gap in the global literature, where studies from low- and middle-income countries are often underrepresented. Furthermore, the inclusion of over 15,000 participants across 21 studies enhances the generalizability of findings within this region.

All included studies were peer-reviewed, and the NOS-cs was used to assess study quality. Notably, all studies were rated as having either a low or moderate risk of bias, with none classified as high risk. This supports the credibility of the synthesized findings.

However, several limitations must be acknowledged. First, all included studies were cross-sectional in design, limiting causal

inference. Second, reliance on self-report measures introduces risks of recall bias, social desirability bias, and misreporting—especially regarding sensitive issues like mental health.

Third, many studies lacked gender-balanced samples or did not stratify results by gender or age subgroups, which could obscure key moderating effects. Fourth, heterogeneity in study characteristics, outcome definitions, assessment methods, and statistical reporting, along with variation in the social media platforms examined, limited the feasibility of conducting a meta-analysis. Fifth, the literature search was subject to geographic constraints, with a lack of reports from certain Arab nations, as well as potential linguistic bias due to the inclusion of only English-language publications.

4.2. Recommendations

We recommend that future research prioritize longitudinal designs to assess causality and explore protective factors such as digital self-regulation, social support, and mindfulness. Interventions developed should integrate psychological education with technological tools, such as app usage monitors or AI (Artificial Intelligence)-driven mental health prompts in native languages. Including culturally competent mental health specialists in intervention planning and execution may help address stigma and adolescents' hesitation to seek assistance. Collaboration between educators, families, mental health professionals, and digital platform developers will be essential in building safer, healthier online environments for Arab youth.

4.3. Conclusion

In summary, this systematic review reveals that frequent and emotionally charged social media use is associated with adverse mental health outcomes among children, adolescents, and young adults in Arab countries. Anxiety, depression, sleep problems, and academic disruption were the most commonly reported issues. Addressing cultural sensitivities, improving digital literacy, and integrating psychological and technological approaches are essential for promoting healthier online engagement and supporting mental well-being among Arab youth.

Ethics approval and consent to participate

Ethical approval and informed consent were not required due to the study's design as a systematic review and the use of anonymized data.

CRediT authorship contribution statement

Amani N. Alansari: Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Project administration, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Abdallah Alwawi:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Amani Salim:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Nizar Tarawah:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Amine Ksia:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization. **Mohamed Sayed Zaazouee:** Writing – review & editing, Writing – original draft, Supervision, Investigation, Data curation, Conceptualization.

Financial Disclosure

This research did not receive any specific grant from funding agencies in the public, commercial, or not-for-profit sectors.

ICMJE statement

All authors contributed to the study design, selection of studies, data

synthesis, and interpretation. All authors participated in drafting and revising the manuscript and approved the final version.

Declaration of Competing Interest

The authors declare that they have no competing financial interests or personal relationships that could be perceived to have influenced the work reported in this paper.

Acknowledgements

The publication of this article was funded by the Qatar National Library.

Appendix A. Supporting information

Supplementary data associated with this article can be found in the online version at [doi:10.1016/j.ajp.2025.104793](https://doi.org/10.1016/j.ajp.2025.104793).

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